FUTUREREADY NYC · NYCPS OFFICE OF STUDENT PATHWAYS

RECRUITMENT & RETENTION PLAYBOOK

What schools must do, grade by grade.
When to do it. How to know it worked.

FUTURE READY NYC

NYC Student Pathways

2026 · FUTUREREADY NYC · VERSION 3

RECRUITMENT & RETENTION PLAYBOOK

WHAT THIS PLAYBOOK IS FOR

This playbook guides school staff through what to do — grade by grade — to build a full, equitable FRNYC cohort and retain students through credential completion. FRNYC places students into career pathways combining Work-Based Learning (WBL), college-credit coursework (ECC), and industry credentials before graduation. Enrollment officially begins in 10th grade; 9th grade is for exploration and interest alignment.

WHO THIS IS FOR

- **FRNYC Coordinators** — manage the full cycle from awareness to completion
- **School Counselors** — identify students, reconcile conflicts, support equitable access
- **APs of Instruction** — priority-schedule pathway classes; lead end-of-year debrief
- **Pathway Teachers** — deliver CCI coursework; connect students to WBL experiences

5 CORE PRINCIPLES OF STRONG RECRUITMENT

1. TIMING (AWARENESS → COMMITMENT)
Recruitment is year-round, starting before students enter high school. Schools that delay until 10th grade struggle to enroll genuinely interested students. Strong programs begin in 8th grade and build through 9th.

2. INTEGRATION (EXPOSURE → EXPERIENCE)
Programs that operate as separate add-ons struggle with both recruitment and retention. Programs embedded in advisory, courses, and school culture see stronger enrollment and persistence.

3. SOCIAL PROOF (AWARENESS → EXPOSURE)
Students are most influenced by other students. Peer-to-peer communication builds trust, makes pathways feel real, and increases interest and enrollment.

4. RELEVANCE (EXPOSURE → COMMITMENT)
Students enroll and stay when they understand what they will do, what they will gain, and how it connects to their future. Concrete examples outperform abstract language like "career readiness."

5. EQUITY (ALL STAGES)
Students with disabilities and multilingual learners are often underrepresented due to structural barriers — not lack of interest. Strong programs track representation, identify barriers, and address them before they become attrition. See the Equity Checklist on page 5.

MILESTONES BY GRADE — KEY CHECKPOINTS

GRADE	MILESTONE	BY WHEN
8th	Feature FRNYC at open house with student ambassadors; begin feeder school outreach	*Fall–Spring*
9th	Interest survey deployed to every 9th grader — responses required (Yes / No / Maybe)	*End of March*
9th	1:1 meetings with interested students using survey responses; cohort confirmed	*April*
9th	FRNYC orientation + parent session for rising 10th graders	*By May*
10th	KIMS enrollment confirmed — ECC data locked for accountability	*October 1*
12th	ECC completion push active; ambassador recruitment underway	*Jan–April*
All	End-of-year debrief complete before staff leave for summer	*Before June 30*

"Lead with what students get — a real-world WBL experience (internship, job shadow, or workplace simulation), college credit, or an industry-recognized credential before graduation — not with what FRNYC is or does."

AWARENESS & OUTREACH

8TH GRADE

8

Goal: 8th graders and their families know your school is a FRNYC school — and are interested enough to choose it.

	HOW TO DO IT	WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE
Promote FRNYC on all school materials	▫ Add "Future Ready NYC" to website, flyers, and social posts — use FRNYC logos from OSP ▫ Lead with outcomes students earn: ECC credits, WBL experience, industry credentials	*Visitors know you're a FRNYC school before they arrive*
Run ambassador-led open house	▫ Brief 2–3 FRNYC students using the Ambassador Script (Student Ambassador Toolkit) ▫ Assign to small groups — conversation beats a stage presentation	*8th graders hear a concrete outcome from a current FRNYC student*
Feeder school outreach + invite to FRNYC event	▫ Contact 3–5 feeder school counselors; offer campus tour or ambassador visit (cold outreach script in Student Ambassador Toolkit) ▫ Invite prospective 8th graders to a student showcase or career fair — no application required	*2+ feeder visits done; prospective students see FRNYC in action*

Year 0: Start with your own students first. Identify 2–3 excited 10th or 11th graders and prepare them as ambassadors before any external outreach — teach each one to share: one concrete outcome they earned, one thing they learned in the program, and why they chose this pathway. That's the whole script. They are your most powerful recruitment asset.

EXPLORATION & INTEREST ALIGNMENT

9TH GRADE

9

Goal: Every 9th grader explores career options and can say whether FRNYC aligns with their interests. Confirmed cohort and orientation completed before end of year.

	HOW TO DO IT	WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE
Career Explorations for all 9th graders, fall–spring	▫ Cover multiple career areas — not only FRNYC; ask: "Which connects to something you care about?" ▫ Note which students ask follow-up questions or express enthusiasm for a specific career area; by end of course, each student writes or states one career area that interests them and one reason why	*Students can say whether FRNYC fits their interests*
Ambassador touchpoints + parent-student panel	▫ Ambassador visits to 9th grade advisories — fall and spring (use Advisory Slide Deck from Student Ambassador Toolkit) ▫ Host at least one parent-student panel per year — format: current FRNYC students share what they've done in the program; parents hear directly from students and ask questions	*Every 9th grader has 2+ direct FRNYC exposures by March*
Interest survey — all 9th graders, March	▫ Google Form to every student — responses required (Yes / No / Maybe); each student explains their choice in 1–2 sentences ▫ Follow up non-responders within 5 days (Coordinator tracks)	*100% response rate; sorted Yes / No / Maybe list by end of March*
1:1 meetings in April → orientation by May	▫ April: 1:1 with each interested student using survey response as agenda; cross-reference with master schedule — conflicts get a conversation, not an exclusion ▫ By May: bring confirmed rising 10th graders together to meet their pathway teacher and current FRNYC students;	*Rising 10th graders enter September knowing their pathway, cohort, and teacher*

COHORT LAUNCH & DEEP ENGAGEMENT

10TH GRADE

10

Goal: Students are officially welcomed into FRNYC as a cohort. WBL experiences align with CCI coursework. Peer community and identity form.

	HOW TO DO IT	*WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE*
Launch cohort + build monthly community cadence	▫ An inaugural FRNYC event (assembly, cohort lunch, or classroom celebration) — welcome rising 10th graders publicly by name; 11th and 12th grade FRNYC students speak briefly about one thing they've done or earned in the program ▫ Schedule monthly FRNYC community time — 30 to 60 minutes, during an advisory block, lunch, or after school — using the Cohort Meeting Guide from the Cohort Toolkit ▫ If students are split across multiple CCI sections, use cohort time to bring them together as a full group — this cross-section peer network is the primary retention driver	*Students feel visible and valued; peers become their support network*
Align WBL with CCI via intermediary partner	▫ Share the CCI course overview with your school's WBL intermediary partner (the organization assigned by OSP to coordinate placements) at the start of the semester — they arrange all WBL opportunities; schools do not place students directly ▫ Confirm 100% of students have a WBL placement aligned to their pathway by October	*Every student sees the connection between coursework and real-world experience*
Family milestone events each semester	▫ At least one family event per semester — Career Discovery week, project showcase, or career panel; structure the presentation around four questions: What will my student earn? What skills are they building? What real-world experience are they getting? How does this help them after graduation? ▫ Translate all materials into the top 3 home languages of the school	*Parents can describe what their student is earning in the program*

SUPPORTIVE SERVICES & POST-SECONDARY PLANNING

11TH GRADE

11

Goal: Academic supports that help students meet ECC eligibility requirements are scheduled into the school day — not offered as optional add-ons. Every student builds a post-secondary plan grounded in their FRNYC experience.

	HOW TO DO IT	*WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE*
Build ECC supports into the schedule	▫ Audit enrollment — identify who needs academic support to meet ECC eligibility requirements (placement scores, GPA thresholds, or prerequisite courses set by the ECC partner institution); schedule tutoring or Regents prep inside the school day (AP of Instruction schedules this) ▫ Coordinate all deadlines and requirements directly with the ECC partner institution (the college or university delivering the ECC course)	*Every student has a clear path to ECC eligibility, with a support plan if needed*
Structured touchpoints + early intervention	▫ 2+ structured group sessions per year (cohort meeting, advisory discussion, or guided reflection) connecting students' current CCI and WBL work to their post-graduation goals; maintain an attendance list and flag any student who misses 2 or more ▫ Warning signals: 3+ missed FRNYC advisory or cohort	*No student exits without a documented conversation first*

COMPLETION & AMBASSADOR PIPELINE

12TH GRADE

12

Goal: Every enrolled student earns their credential before graduation. Completers become next year's ambassadors. The cycle renews.

	HOW TO DO IT	*WHAT SUCCESS LOOKS LIKE*
KIMS review — September	▫ Pull each student's ECC record from KIMS — create a list: on-track (enrolled and progressing) vs. needs-support (enrollment gap, missing coursework, or at risk of not completing); if it's not in KIMS, it won't count toward the school's accountability data ▫ By October 1: every at-risk student has a written plan specifying what they still need to complete and what support they will receive (Coordinator tracks; Principal is the accountability holder)	*Every student's ECC status is known by October 1*
ECC partner coordination	▫ Establish a direct contact at the ECC partner institution; know all enrollment, withdrawal, and grade reporting deadlines ▫ When a student is struggling, contact the ECC partner liaison directly — do not wait for a grade report; ask what academic support or withdrawal options exist before mid-semester, because options narrow quickly after that point	*No credit lost due to a missed administrative deadline*
Completion push (Jan–Apr) + ambassador recruitment	▫ In January: check ECC progress for every 12th grader via KIMS and a direct update from the ECC partner; weekly check-ins for anyone behind pace — be specific: "You need to complete [assignment or unit] by [date] to stay on track for the credential" ▫ Recruit 3–5 completing seniors as ambassadors — ask directly, not via announcement; before graduation, meet with them to explain the role: attending next year's open house, doing 2–3 advisory visits, and sharing their experience with prospective students	*90%+ earn credential before graduation; 3+ ambassadors confirmed*
End-of-year debrief before staff leave	▫ Coordinator + AP + Counselor: review % who completed, where drop-offs occurred, 3 specific changes for next cycle ▫ File the written debrief before June 30 — the findings should directly shape next fall's open house messaging and which feeder schools to prioritize	*Written debrief on file; 3 specific changes identified for next year*

EQUITY CHECKLIST — SWD & MLL ACCESS

Review each barrier below at enrollment and again at mid-year — check whether it applies to your school. Underrepresentation is a structural problem — not a preferences problem.

BARRIER TO WATCH FOR	WHAT TO DO
IEP mandated services or pull-out schedules create scheduling conflicts that block SWD students from the cohort — often without anyone flagging it	Cross-reference the "Yes"/"Maybe" survey list with the master schedule before the cohort is finalized. Students blocked by scheduling get a 1:1 conversation to explore alternatives — period swaps, modified pull-out schedules, or an alternate CCI section. Flag to the AP before the cohort is finalized.
Open house materials, interest survey, and pathway descriptions are English-only	Translate all core materials (open house flyer, interest survey, orientation communication) into the top 3 home languages of your school — request translation support from the ENL department or your network office. Recruit bilingual student ambassadors to represent those languages.
ECC courses at partner colleges often require college-level placement in math or English — SWD and MLL students may qualify via different pathways but get	Audit prerequisite lists annually. Identify what is a confirmed requirement set by the partner institution vs. an internal assumption that can be challenged. Escalate structural barriers to your AP and OSP.